



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: June 19, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	I investigated a phishing email incident using the 5 W's framework. The activity focused on identifying the source of the attack, analyzing the impact, and documenting the findings. This supported the Detection and Analysis phase of the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle by helping determine whether the event was a security incident.
Tool(s) used	Email headers, Incident Handler's Journal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • An unknown external attacker sent a phishing email. • What happened? • A phishing email attempted to trick an employee into revealing login credentials. • When did the incident occur? • During routine monitoring of employee email activity. • Where did the incident happen? • The organization's email environment.

	• Why did the incident happen? • To steal credentials and gain unauthorized access to company resources.
Additional notes	The 5 W's helped organize the investigation and clearly document the incident.

Date: June 19th, 2026	Entry: 2
Description	I analyzed network traffic using Wireshark to identify communication between devices and examine packet details. This activity improved my understanding of packet analysis and helped identify protocols used during network communication.
Tool(s) used	• Wireshark captures packets in real time. • It displays protocol information, source and destination IP addresses, and packet details. • Packet analysis helps identify suspicious network behavior. • Wireshark supports the Detection and Analysis phase of incident response.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • What happened? • When did the incident occur?

	• Where did the incident happen? • Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Learning to inspect packets made it easier to understand how network attacks can be detected.

Date: June 19th, 2026	Entry: 3
Description	I investigated a suspicious file hash using VirusTotal. The investigation confirmed that the file matched known malicious indicators. This activity demonstrated how threat intelligence helps security analysts quickly identify malware.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • A malicious actor distributed the infected file. • What happened? • A suspicious file hash was identified and analyzed. • When did the incident occur? • During a malware investigation. • Where did the incident happen? • On a workstation within the organization. • Why did the incident happen?

	To determine whether the file posed a security risk.
Additional notes	Threat intelligence platforms speed up investigations by comparing indicators with known threats.

Date: June 19, 2026	Entry: 4
Description	I performed security log analysis using Splunk and Google Chronicle. I searched logs, filtered events, and identified suspicious activities using queries. This activity strengthened my understanding of SIEM tools and log investigation.
Tool(s) used	Splunk Google Chronicle Search Processing Language (SPL)
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. Who caused the incident? What happened? When did the incident occur? Where did the incident happen? Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	SIEM tools allow analysts to investigate large volumes of logs efficiently and quickly identify indicators of compromise.

Date: June 19, 2026	Entry: 5
Description	I used a security incident response playbook to respond to a ransomware attack. The activity demonstrated the importance of following standardized procedures to contain threats, recover affected systems, and minimize business impact. This aligned with the Containment, Eradication, and Recovery phase of the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle.
Tool(s) used	Incident Response Playbook Security documentation
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • A ransomware attacker targeted the organization. • What happened? • Malware encrypted files and disrupted normal operations. • When did the incident occur? • During routine monitoring after suspicious activity was detected. • Where did the incident happen? • On multiple employee workstations within the organization. • Why did the incident happen? • To demand a ransom payment in exchange for restoring access to the encrypted files.
Additional notes	Using a playbook reduced confusion and ensured the incident response process was organized and consistent.

Date: June 19, 2026	Entry: 6
Description	I reviewed a completed incident report to understand how security teams document investigations, identify lessons learned, and recommend future improvements. This activity reinforced the importance of accurate documentation during the Post-Incident Activity phase of the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle.
Tool(s) used	Incident Report Security Documentation
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • What happened? • When did the incident occur? • Where did the incident happen? • Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Reviewing the final report showed me how detailed documentation supports continuous improvement and strengthens future incident response efforts.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

The activities involving packet analysis with Wireshark and log analysis using Splunk and Chronicle were the most challenging because they required careful attention to technical details. As I practiced using these tools, I became more confident in identifying suspicious activity and understanding how security analysts investigate incidents.

2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?

Yes. Before taking this course, I only had a basic understanding of incident response. I now understand the complete NIST Incident Response Lifecycle, the importance of documenting incidents using the 5 W's, and how security teams detect, analyze, contain, recover from, and learn from security incidents.

3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

I enjoyed working with Splunk the most because it allowed me to search and analyze large amounts of security log data efficiently. I also found Wireshark interesting because it helped me understand how network packets are captured and analyzed to identify suspicious network activity and potential security threats.